

GST101

Use of English and Communication Skills I

Course Summary

Ubora World Study Companion

About This Summary

This summary condenses the core ideas of GST101 (Use of English and Communication Skills I) into a quick-reference study guide. It covers all 4 modules and 20 study units: listening skills, reading skills, vocabulary development, and reading diverse text types. Use it to revise before practicing with the CBT question bank, not as a replacement for the full course material.

Module 1: Listening Skills

Listening Enabling Skills

A listener is anyone capable of listening to what is said and participating as required. Listening activities fall into two broad categories: everyday social listening, and listening for specific purposes such as gathering information or following an academic lecture. Enabling skills for effective listening include functioning ears, concentration, thinking along with the speaker, anticipating what comes next, and picking up on signposting expressions such as "as I said before" or "consequently," which signal relationships between ideas.

Listening and Comprehending

Listening is only useful if it leads to comprehension. To comprehend effectively, a listener should listen attentively, follow the speaker's train of thought, and build a wide vocabulary around the subject being discussed. Passive, casual listening typically yields only the major points, while attentive listening captures specific supporting details.

Listening: Comprehension and Note-Taking

Note-taking (from live lectures/talks) is distinct from note-making (from books and written texts). Good notes are neat, organised under clear headings and sub-headings, and leave room for later additions. The most important habit is to remove irrelevant material rather than transcribing everything word for word.

Listening-Comprehension and Information Retrieval: General

Through careful listening, students can retrieve instructions, directions, and facts, then combine these pieces into a general impression of what was communicated. This unit builds the skill of selectively extracting only the information that is actually needed.

Listening-Comprehension and Information Retrieval: Data, Figures, Diagrams and Charts

Information is not always delivered in plain sentences — speakers often refer to figures, diagrams, and charts. This unit trains students to follow along and fill in visual aids (tables, charts) in real time as the relevant data is being spoken about.

Module 2: Main Idea, Critical Listening, and Effective Reading

Listening for the Main Idea

Identifying the main idea of a talk or lecture helps focus study time and avoid burnout from trying to memorise everything indiscriminately. Speakers signal main ideas by repeating them, stating them in the title, or using cue phrases such as "the crucial issue we are grappling with is..." or "the most

important point is...".

Listening for Interpretation and Critical Evaluation

Interpretation means deriving both surface and deeper meaning from what is said, including inferencing beyond the literal words. Critical analysis goes further, weighing the merits and demerits of an argument and forming reasoned judgements and conclusions.

Effective Reading

Effective reading is a deliberate process: decide your purpose for reading, preview the material, form a guiding question, and take notes as you go. This turns reading from a passive activity into an active, comprehension-focused one.

Skimming and Scanning

Skimming is the fastest reading speed, used to get a general overview or gist of a passage without needing full comprehension — if it takes too long, you are likely reading at average speed rather than truly skimming. Scanning is used to locate a specific piece of information quickly, without reading the whole text.

Reading and Comprehending at Varying Speed Levels I

Building on skimming and scanning, this unit introduces the concept of matching your reading speed to your purpose — different texts and different goals call for different speeds, and reading slowly does not automatically guarantee better comprehension.

Module 3: Study-Speed Reading and Vocabulary Development

Reading and Comprehending at Varying Speed Levels II

Study-type reading is the slowest, most detailed reading speed, used when full understanding is essential. This unit pairs study-speed reading with note-making from books, reusing the note-making format introduced in Module 1. The guiding principle is that speed and accuracy must be balanced together.

Reading for Vocabulary Development I

New or unfamiliar words can often be understood through "word attack" strategies and by searching the surrounding passage for contextual clues, rather than stopping to check a dictionary every time.

Reading for Vocabulary Development II

Additional vocabulary strategies include lexical familiarisation, drawing on personal past experience, and using a dictionary effectively once other context-based strategies have been tried first.

Vocabulary Development in Various Academic Contexts (Part I)

This unit exposes students to vocabulary associated with psychology, law, medicine/paramedical fields, and education — building comfort with terminology outside one's own department.

Vocabulary Development in Various Academic Contexts (Part II)

This unit continues into vocabulary from the arts, accounting, and the natural sciences, showing that many words (like "continuous" or "primary") shift meaning depending on the field and context they appear in. The broader aim across both units is to build a habit of extensive reading outside your

specialisation.

Module 4: Reading Diverse Texts

Reading Diverse Texts: Narratives

Narrative texts tell stories and are the most commonly read text type. They follow a storyline — background, plot, climax, and resolution — usually organised in sequential or chronological order, and they keep readers engaged through suspense.

Reading Diverse Texts: Expository Texts

Unlike narratives, expository texts explain an issue, theory, concept, or plan rather than telling a story. They are more formal in style (limited contractions and colloquialisms) and are expected to be factual, with claims backed by concrete evidence.

Reading and Comprehending Passages with Tables

Some reading-comprehension exercises combine prose with non-verbal information such as tables, figures, and diagrams. A well-designed table can present facts more vividly and briefly than several paragraphs of text, so students need specific skills to interpret them alongside the surrounding prose.

Reading Scientific Texts

Science underlies transport, telecommunications, medicine, agriculture, and many other areas of everyday life, so reading scientific texts benefits every student, not only those in science disciplines. Reasons for engaging with scientific texts include building world knowledge and learning to apply scientific understanding to personal growth and development.

Reading for Interpretation and Critical Evaluation

The course closes by combining earlier skills: first read and understand a passage thoroughly, then read between and above the lines to infer what is implied but not directly stated. Critical questions such as "to what extent" or "how effective or successful" guide deeper evaluation, and this kind of reading is best done at a careful, study-level pace.

Quick Revision Checklist

- Know the difference between listening in general social settings vs. listening for specific purposes.
- Be able to list the listening enabling skills (functioning ears, concentration, anticipation, signpost awareness).
- Distinguish note-taking (from speech) from note-making (from text).
- Recognise cue phrases that signal a speaker's main idea.
- Know the difference between interpretation and critical analysis.
- Understand skimming (fast, general overview) vs. scanning (fast, specific detail).
- Understand why reading speed and comprehension are not always directly correlated.
- Know the vocabulary-building strategies: word attack, context search, lexical familiarisation, dictionary use.
- Be able to distinguish narrative texts (tell a story) from expository texts (explain a concept).
- Understand why tables can communicate information more efficiently than paragraphs in some cases.
- Know why reading scientific texts matters for all students, not just science majors.
- Understand the two stages of reading for interpretation: full comprehension first, then inference.